The Weekend Protocol

The week is rarely the problem.

Why the weekend keeps doing what it does, the choice worth making honestly, and the three decisions that change it.

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01

Why it keeps happening

Monday to Friday has scaffolding in it. A wake time, a commute, meetings, a shape to the day that you did not have to invent. Saturday has almost none of that, and it is the structure that goes missing rather than the willpower.

You did not really decide

Most weekend eating and drinking is not a decision that got made badly. It is a response to a cue. Friday evening, the couch, the pub, the glass in your hand, the menu on the phone. The sequence was already set long before anything that felt like a choice came into it, and by the time you noticed, you were three steps in.

That is worth knowing, because it moves the job. You are not trying to get better at resisting in the moment. You are trying to get the decision made earlier.

Then Saturday bleeds into Sunday

One unplanned evening quietly becomes a written-off weekend. I have already broken it, so what is the point. That is the all-or-nothing thinking, and it costs far more than the night that started it.

The arithmetic, which is worth seeing once

Say your maintenance is 2,500 calories a day, so 17,500 across the week.

MONDAY TO FRIDAY	THE WEEKEND	NET FOR THE WEEK
2,000 a day, so a 500 deficit each day	Two days at around 3,500	
2,500 under	2,000 over	500 under

Five days of good work, and what is left of it at the end of the week is minimal. That is not a reason to feel bad. It is just the reason a good week can produce nothing on the scales, and it explains the frustration.

02

Pick one, honestly

Here is where most of the discomfort actually comes from, and it is not the food or the drink.

> I WANT TO MAKE PROGRESS
>
> Hit the target. Train consistently. Wake up Monday feeling good about it. Keep the momentum going.
>
> I WANT TO THE FULL WEEKEND
>
> Pints on tap. The cheeseboard. The Saturday session. Say yes to everything that is going.

Both of those are perfectly reasonable things to want. The trouble is wanting them both at the same time, on the same weekend, and then being disappointed on Monday.

So make the choice on purpose. Have the full weekend and let go of the expectation that the scales weight will drop on Monday. Or stay on the horse and accept that you are sitting a few things out. Either one is fine, and different weekends will have different results.

What does not work is going in without deciding, doing a bit of both, and then giving yourself a hard time about it on Monday morning.

> THE DIAL
>
> There is a straightforward trade underneath all of this. The more attention and planning you give your food, the quicker this moves. If you want the open catalogue where everything is on the table, that is a completely fine choice, but the expectation has to come down with it. Smaller changes, over a longer stretch of time.

Most of us end up somewhere in the middle, and we move up and down the dial depending on what is on that particular weekend. That is normal. Just know where you are sitting before Friday rather than working it out on Monday.

03

The three decisions

Made early Friday. Not on Saturday, and not at nine o'clock on Friday evening.

> ONE
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> **If you are drinking, what is the number and what time are you finishing?** Decided in advance it tends to hold. Decided at the bar it is not really a number, it is a hope.
>
> TWO
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> **What is the training session, and when?** One session across the weekend, with a day and a time attached to it. Saturday morning before anything else starts competing is a good call.
>
> THREE
>
> **What is in the fridge on Saturday morning?** If the answer is nothing, that is Friday's job. A weekend with no protein in the house makes the decision for you.

And one rule that goes with them

Eat properly before you go out, not after. A guy who arrives fed makes different decisions for the rest of the night, and it is the single easiest thing to do.

Say them to someone

Tell someone. Your wife, the group, one of the lads. Tell someone what your plan is.

04

Saturday and Sunday

Saturday morning is the anchor

Get up somewhere near your normal time, get outside early even for ten minutes, and get a proper protein breakfast in. That is three early wins.

The early light is worth mentioning on its own. Even on a grey morning it helps set you up for a better night's sleep that night.

Steps are where the weekend is won

Walk after meals, take the stairs, park further away, bring the kids somewhere that involves moving.

Exercise snacks

Short bursts of movement spread through the day. Thirty seconds to a few minutes, repeated, and no gym needed.

- A ten minute walk after a meal
- Stairs instead of the lift
- Squats while you're waiting for the match to kick off on TV
- Playing with the kids

They are a support rather than a replacement for training. What they do well is break up long stretches of sitting and take the edge off the blood sugar rise after eating, and they are far easier to keep up than another intense session.

Do not bank calories by skipping meals

Saving yourself for the evening is the most common weekend plan and the one that works least often. You arrive somewhere starving, you drink faster, and every decision after that is a regrettable one.

Sunday quietly sets Monday

Twenty minutes on a Sunday, some protein cooked off and into the fridge, and the week starts on the front foot rather than in a shop on Monday evening.

05

The Monday reset

Some weekends will go the way you wanted and some will not. What happens on Monday matters more than what happened on Saturday.

No guilt spiral

The weekend is done and feeling bad about it does not undo any of it. One heavy weekend inside four weeks is noise. A guilt spiral that runs on into Wednesday is the thing that actually does damage.

Assess it honestly

Was it worth it? If it was, own it and move on, and no apology needed. If it was not, the useful question is what you would do differently next Friday. Not why did I do that, but what did that teach me about my own patterns and how much my goal means to me.

One good decision, not a plan

Do not try to repair the weekend on Monday morning. No punishment session, no skipping breakfast to balance the books. Make one good decision and let it lead to the next one. A protein breakfast. A walk. Getting the session done.

> THE WAY TO THINK ABOUT IT
>
> An athlete does not write off a season because of one bad game. He reviews it, takes something from it, and plays the next one. The weekend was one game. The season is still going.

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